

Who's Really Watching? Fixing Instagram's Story Replay Blind Spot

Summary

Instagram Pro users can't see who specifically rewatched their story multiple times; they only see a total replay count. On top of that, viewer data disappears after 48 hours, so even the limited data that exists doesn't stick around long enough to act on. I surveyed 8 people and confirmed both problems, though I also learned that half of respondents rarely or never check story insights at all, which is worth keeping in mind.

I compared 4 possible fixes using RICE scoring. One idea (a weekly email) scored slightly higher on paper, but I chose a different one, a new "Top Repeat Viewers" section with a longer 30-day data window because it's backed by real complaints from the survey, not just a guess. This fix was broken into 10 tasks across two planned sprints. Success would be measured by how many Pro users actually engage with the new section after launch.

Problem Definition

What's broken: Instagram's Professional Dashboard shows aggregate story replay counts (e.g., "this story was replayed 340 times"), but gives no breakdown of *who* rewatched a story or *how many times* each individual viewer replayed it. A story replayed 340 times by 340 different people looks identical in the data to one replayed 34 times by just 10 highly engaged viewers — even though these represent very different levels of interest

Who it affects: Creators and small businesses using Instagram Pro accounts who rely on story insights to gauge genuine audience interest and identify high-intent followers. This is especially relevant for small businesses using Instagram as a sales channel, where a repeat viewer often signals a warmer lead than a one-time viewer

Size estimate: Instagram Pro is used by an estimated tens of millions of creators and small businesses globally. Assuming even a modest 10-15% actively check story insights to inform engagement or outreach decisions, the current lack of per-viewer granularity means a meaningful share of businesses are missing a low-effort, high-signal way to identify their most interested followers -a gap with direct implications for lead generation and customer relationship building.

Why it matters: Replay behavior is one of the strongest passive engagement signals Instagram already collects if a user doesn't replay a story by accident. Surfacing *who* is repeatedly engaging, not just how many total replays occurred, would let businesses act on interest signals they're currently blind to (e.g., following up with a viewer who replayed a product story five times). Without this, Instagram is sitting on a valuable signal it isn't surfacing to the users who would benefit most from it.

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Research Findings

I surveyed 8 Instagram users to test the problem hypothesis above. Key results:

- 50% rarely or never check their story insights, and 12.5% didn't know the feature existed meaning less than half of respondents actively engage with insights in the first place.
- 50% have wondered "who specifically" rewatched their story at least sometimes or often.
- 25% said knowing individual repeat viewers would "definitely" change how they use the app; another 37.5% said "maybe."

From the open-ended responses, two related themes emerged:

1. Missing per-viewer visibility (the original hypothesis): "Cannot find who is rewatching the story multiple times and cannot edit the story after posting." This confirms the core problem, though it was raised unprompted by only 1 of 8 respondents.
2. Data expiring too fast (an unprompted, stronger complaint): "The list of people who viewed the stories vanish after 48 hours." This is arguably a bigger blocker than the granularity issue, since it prevents users from acting on any insights data, not just per-viewer detail.

Decision: Rather than treating these as separate problems, I scoped the chosen fix to address both adding per-viewer visibility and extending the data retention window since the research suggested they're closely connected pain points for the same underlying need: being able to act on replay data before it disappears.

RICE Scoring & Decision

A	B	C	D	E	F	G
Fix Idea	Reach	Impact	Confidence	Effort	Rice Score	Rank
Per-viewer replay badge	5	1	0.7	3	1.16666667	3
Top Repeat Viewers section + 30-day retention	6	2	0.8	7	1.371428571	2
Extend retention to 30 days only	6	1	0.9	6	0.9	4
Weekly digest email of top repeat viewers	7	2	0.5	5	1.4	1

Idea 4 (weekly digest email) scored marginally highest, but its Confidence score was low (50%) because no survey respondent actually requested that it was a speculative addition on my part, not evidence-backed.

I chose Idea 2 ("Top Repeat Viewers" section with 30-day retention) instead. Even though its RICE score was slightly lower, it's directly supported by two separate real complaints from user research, making it a more defensible, evidence-based bet than chasing a marginally higher score built on a guess.

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"Execution Plan."

Task Order & Dependencies

The backend changes to store data longer (KAN-3, KAN-4) need to be done first, before we can track how people use the new analytics events (KAN-5, KAN-6). It doesn't make sense to measure usage of a feature that doesn't have real data behind it yet. The design work (KAN-1, KAN-7) can happen at the same time as the backend work, since the two don't depend on each other.

Timeline

- Week 1: Design the "Top Repeat Viewers" layout, decide how viewers get ranked, extend the retention policy, design the empty state (KAN-1, 2, 3, 7)
- Week 2: Update backend storage to support 30-day retention (KAN-4)
- Week 3: Add analytics tracking, write tooltip copy (KAN-5, 6, 9)
- Week 4: QA testing, build the post-launch tracking dashboard, launch (KAN-8, 10)

Risks

1. Tracking individual viewers this closely might feel invasive to people who don't realize they're being watched this specifically.
Fix: only show this data to the account owner, never notify the person being tracked.
2. Keeping data for longer (30 days instead of 48 hours) will cost more to store.
Fix: start with 30 days, watch the cost, and adjust later if needed.
3. People might not notice the new feature exists.
Fix: launch the in-app tooltip (KAN-9) at the same time as the feature, not after.
4. The research is based on only 8 survey responses, so real behavior once it's live could be different.
Fix: track actual usage through analytics events (KAN-5, 6) after launch, and be ready to make changes.
5. The backend work to extend data retention was probably estimated too optimistically.
Fix: call this out as the riskiest task early, and check in with engineering before locking the schedule.

Supporting Materials

- RICE scoring spreadsheet:  *Instagram Story Insights — RICE Scoring*
- Survey Link: <https://forms.gle/8sbsk46bcwurQRq47>
- JIRA sprint planning:

Who's Really Watching? Fixing Instagram's Story Replay Blind Spot

Spaces

IG Story Insights

Summary

List

Board

Calendar

Docs

Backlog

Search backlog

Filter

Board

(10 work items)

0

10

0

KAN-1

Design "Top Repeat Viewers" section layout for insights dashboard

Top Repeat Viewer...

To Do

KAN-2

Define ranking logic (sort viewers by replay count, descending)

Top Repeat Viewer...

To Do

KAN-4

Update backend storage to support 30-day retention window

Top Repeat Viewer...

To Do

KAN-5

Add analytics event: "Top Repeat Viewers" section viewed

Top Repeat Viewer...

To Do

KAN-6

Add analytics event: individual viewer profile clicked from section

Top Repeat Viewer...

To Do

KAN-7

Design empty state (for stories with no repeat viewers yet)

Top Repeat Viewer...

To Do

KAN-8

QA: verify replay counts reset correctly per new story

Top Repeat Viewer...

To Do

KAN-9

Write in-app tooltip explaining the new section and retention change

Top Repeat Viewer...

To Do

KAN-10

Build post-launch dashboard tracking % of Pro users who view the new section

Top Repeat Viewer...

To Do

KAN-3

Extend data retention policy from 48 hours to 30 days

Top Repeat Viewer...

To Do

+ Create